

THE KEY PLAYERS

The honchos who control India's largest business group in areas ranging from salt and steel to IT and telecom



NOEL TATA
Chairman, Tata Trusts

Half-brother of Ratan Tata; also Chair of Trent and Tata International

► He has been associated with the Tata group for over four decades. In addition to his position on Tata Trusts, he is chairman of Trent, Tata International, Voltas, and Tata Investment Corporation. He is also Vice Chairman of Tata Steel and Titan. His notable success has been Trent in fashion, and Star in the supermarket format.



venu srinivasan
(Vice Chairman, Tata Trusts)

Chairman Emeritus, TVS Motor Co.; seen as close to Ratan Tata

► A member of Tata Trusts and its nominee on the board of Tata Sons, the investment holding company and promoter of the Tata group. He is also Chairman Emeritus of TVS Motor, a leading manufacturer of two-wheelers. He joined the board of Tata Sons in August 2016.



VIJAY SINGH
(Vice Chairman, Tata Trusts)

Former defence secretary; long-time confidant of Ratan Tata

► Till recently, was a nominee on the board of Tata Sons. He reportedly stepped down from the position in September. A former defence secretary, he joined the board of Tata Sons in 2013 and resigned before returning in February 2022. In the past, he has been on boards of several Tata companies.



PRAMIT JHAVERI
Trustee

Former India Chief Executive Officer, Citigroup

► Jhaveri later moved up as Vice-Chairman (Banking) for the Asia-Pacific region. He joined the Sir Dorabji Trust in early 2020. Jhaveri sits on boards of Bajaj Finance, Bajaj Finserv, and Larsen & Toubro. He also serves as an advisor and mentor to start-ups, corporates, and family offices.

But in less than a year, fissures began to appear. The first signs came in September, when Vijay Singh, a long-time trustee and former defence secretary, stepped down as director of Tata Sons. Singh, who first joined the board in 2013 and returned in 2022 after age limits were relaxed, found his reappointment blocked by four trustees. He tells *Business Today* he is “not disappointed” but says “there has been no consensus or unanimity in decision-making. If Mr. Tata were here, he would have behaved very differently.”

When asked what had changed in the past year, Singh says, “To a large extent, things have come apart at Tata Trusts, though it has been exemplary at Tata Sons. Eventually, some kind of an equilibrium will be restored.”

Trust sources, on their part, maintained that the deci-

sion was generational. “Since the group is deeply invested in high-tech areas, it was felt a younger person would be better suited,” one said.

Among those said to have opposed Singh’s reappointment was Mehli Mistry—cousin of the late Cyrus Mistry and a long-time associate of Ratan Tata. He is a trustee of both the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, and director of the Meherji Pallonji Group, which has interests in logistics, shipping, and financial services.

During the 2016 boardroom battle that led to Cyrus Mistry’s ouster as Tata Sons Chairman, Mehli Mistry had sided with Ratan Tata. His growing influence within the Trusts has now reportedly become a point of internal friction.

Reports suggest that some trustees proposed his in-